

2.1 Installing Linux

Morbid fear reigns amongst most folk on the issue of Linux installation procedure. The fact is, it's not rocket science (any more!). You simply need to follow the on-screen instructions and choose what you want. But given the vast customisation choices that Linux installations offer, sometimes even knowing what you want can be a problem.

Here we will to tell you something about a typical installation procedure. Of course, we maintain that the best way to learn is to experiment, relying on the trial and error method. Backed, undoubtedly by some logic and common sense—you don't want to be risking your precious music files or your memorable photos in case you choose a wrong format option that will wipe your disk off, do you?

Understanding the following will be easier if you've done a Windows install. In fact, the basic processes involved in setting up the two OSes are similar. And the risk of losing your data during a Linux installation is more or less the same as during a Windows install. If someone told you Linux is this untamable, fickle-minded beast that throws tantrums—well, disregard such 'expert' opinions. In fact, we recently installed a cool distribution of Linux called Ubuntu—the installation went off without a hitch—and this chapter is right now being written in OpenOffice on Linux! We don't see such an installation being a hassle for you either—so, folks, breathe easy!

2.1.1 Acquiring the OS

As we have said earlier, for some versions, you pay the shipping and CD costs, while some come totally free (yes—Ubuntu for example!). There are several versions that can simply be downloaded from the Internet and burnt onto a CD that can then be used to boot and install the OS. The download files are generally in the .iso format, which is nothing but an image of a CD. Use a CD burning software such as Nero, which supports burning .iso files to CD.